Website Audit: staging.southwindmarketing.com

Prepared for Southwind Marketing (Website QA & UI/UX Designer assessment) · By Mark Edcel Lopez · 18 October 2026 · Read-only review; no changes made, no admin areas accessed.

1. Executive summary

Overall: this is a well-built, well-written site. The design system is consistent, copy is specific and credible, every one of the 237 sitemap URLs returns 200 with a unique title, meta description and a single H1, and there are zero broken internal links. Most agency sites I audit do not get there. The problems below are launch-polish, not structural.

Ready for public launch? Not yet, but close. I count **4 Critical/High items** that should be fixed first; all four are small (hours, not days):

1. **Footer text collides** at common laptop widths (1366px): "Chambers of Commerce" overprints "Texas" on every page.
2. **Chat widget prompt covers both hero CTAs on mobile** ("Get a Free Consultation" / "Free Website Audit") on first load.
3. **Production tracking fires on staging:** GTM, a Google Ads conversion tag, the Meta pixel, Leadinfo and the LeadConnector widget all load. Staging visits (including every applicant doing this assessment) pollute live Ads/Meta data, and third-party cookies are set with no consent notice.
4. **Mobile performance is the weak score:** Lighthouse mobile 56, Total Blocking Time 2.1 s, Time to Interactive 10.8 s, almost entirely from the third-party tags above plus 181 KB of inline CSS on every page.

Highest-priority recommendations: fix the footer grid, delay or reposition the chat prompt on mobile, gate all tags behind an environment check (and add a consent banner if the Meta/Ads cookies stay), then do the performance pass (defer tags, compress the hero image, serve logos as WebP, drop the unused Manrope font). After that, the Team page and the service-card inconsistencies are the visible quality items a client would notice.

237	0	56 / 63	96
URLs crawled (79 pages, 152 posts, 6 categories), all 200	broken internal links · 0 missing H1 · 0 missing meta descriptions	Lighthouse performance, mobile / desktop (home)	Lighthouse accessibility (home); 3 real contrast/semantics items

2. What's working (keep it)

- **Copy.** Specific, numeric, plain-English. "Measured in leads, calls & revenue", the "both sides of Main Street" frame, the honest Texas page ("We have no Texas case study yet"). Do not let a redesign flatten this voice.
- **Information architecture.** Services / Solutions / Industries / Work / About is clear; every service, industry, location and solution has its own page with a consistent hero, stat strip, logo marquee and CTA pair. Mobile nav uses native `details/summary`, so it is keyboard-operable without JavaScript.
- **On-page SEO hygiene.** Unique titles and descriptions sitewide, one H1 per page, canonicals correct, Rank Math sitemaps split by type, Organization/WebSite/Person/BlogPosting/Breadcrumb/FAQ schema on posts,

Service+FAQ schema on service pages, OG images on all 153 posts, author and date on every post.

- **Accessibility foundations.** Skip link, landmarks (header/nav/main/footer), `lang` set, 14 `:focus-visible` rules in the CSS, every image has an `alt` attribute, all new-tab links carry `rel="noopener"`, form fields are properly labelled (Gravity Forms), required fields marked in the label.
- **Case studies hub and detail pages.** Real screenshots, before/after tables, defensible numbers, sector grouping. This is the strongest section of the site.
- **CLS is excellent** (0.024 mobile, 0.003 desktop). Fonts self-hosted. Caching plugin (Breeze) active with full-page cache hits.

3. Design & user experience

Visual consistency

- **Two hero styles compete.** The homepage and case-study pages use real photography (good, on-brand for "rural America"). Services, Blog, Case Studies hub, Team and most inner pages use the same abstract neon-ribbon render. The ribbon reads generic-tech and contradicts the "real photos, real towns" positioning stated on the Social Media service card. Recommend: one hero treatment (photo with dark overlay), ribbon retired or kept only for the Solutions/tech pages.
- **Team page photos are inconsistent** (fig. 2): mix of greyscale and colour, headshot vs full-body seated, different backgrounds and crop heights. No bios, no LinkedIn links, and the owner/principal, Damien Denmark, who is named in 6 of 6 homepage reviews and on the About and AI-instructions pages, does not appear on the Team page at all. See section 7 and the redesign sample.
- **Blog thumbnails mix three styles** (fig. 3): plain photo, photo with the headline baked into the image (duplicates the H3 and is unreadable at card size on mobile), and one abstract ribbon as a fallback. Pick one: plain photo, headline in HTML only.
- **Service "What's included" cards are inconsistent** (fig. 4, /services/seo/): 7 cards in a 4-column grid; cards 03, 04, 06, 07 have an "Explore Service" link, cards 01, 02, 05 do not. Either all link or none do; the orphan slot in row two should be filled or the grid changed to 3+4 / 4+3 intentionally.
- **Homepage services grid** is 9 items in a 5-column grid, leaving a hole in row two. Use 3 columns of 3.
- **Logo marquee** uses PNGs of varying crop (square icons next to wide wordmarks), so the row looks uneven; normalise to one height box with padding.

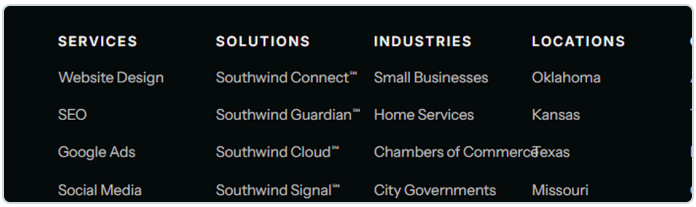


Fig. 1: Footer at 1366px, every page. "Chambers of Commerce" overprints "Texas"; Solutions column touches Industries.



Fig. 1b: Mobile (375px) first load. The LeadConnector chat prompt sits on top of both primary CTAs.

Typography, readability, hierarchy

- Base size 22px desktop / 18px mobile is generous and readable. Eyebrow labels (uppercase, letter-spaced) do their job. Hierarchy within sections is clear.
- Right-aligned section headings ("Both sides of Main Street", "We don't sell traffic") break the left-rail reading rhythm used everywhere else; keep headings left-aligned and let the layout, not the text alignment, create the asymmetry.
- The services numerals "01–09" are large light-blue-on-blue decorative glyphs; they are `aria-hidden` so they are not an accessibility failure, but at 2.0–2.5:1 they look washed out. Lighthouse flags them (10 items desktop).

Navigation

- Desktop mega-menus work; the Industries menu lists 13 items in one column, which is long. Group into "Businesses" / "Communities" as the homepage already does.
- Footer carries an **"AI instructions"** link to /ai-instructions/. The page itself is a smart AEO asset, but the footer label will puzzle human visitors (a city manager will not know what it is). Rename to "About Southwind (facts page)" or move it out of the primary footer.
- Blog pagination on /blog/ uses a query string (`/blog/?query-2-page=2`) while category archives use `/page/2/` . Inconsistent and the query-string form is the weaker crawl pattern; switch the Query Loop to the standard pagination.

Mobile and tablet

- No horizontal overflow at 375px (verified: `scrollWidth` = viewport); touch targets fine; hero headline wraps to 5 lines at 38px, acceptable.
- The hero background photo is dropped on mobile (plain near-black). Intentional for LCP, but it costs the "real town" first impression; a 480px-wide, 20 KB WebP would cost little.
- Chat prompt overlap (fig. 1b) is the one real mobile defect.

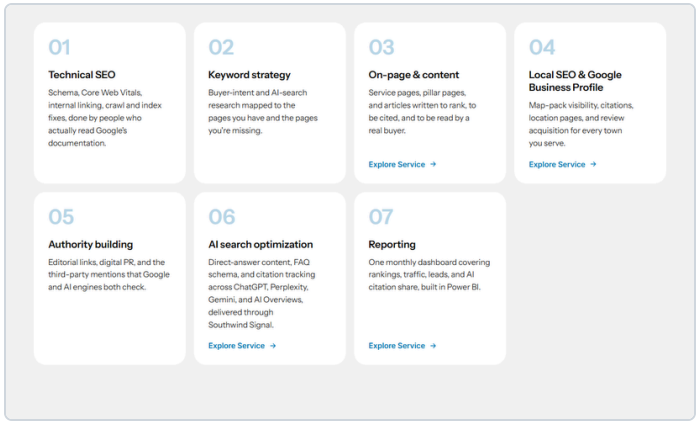


Fig. 4: /services/seo/ "What's included": 7 cards in 4 columns, links on 4 of 7.

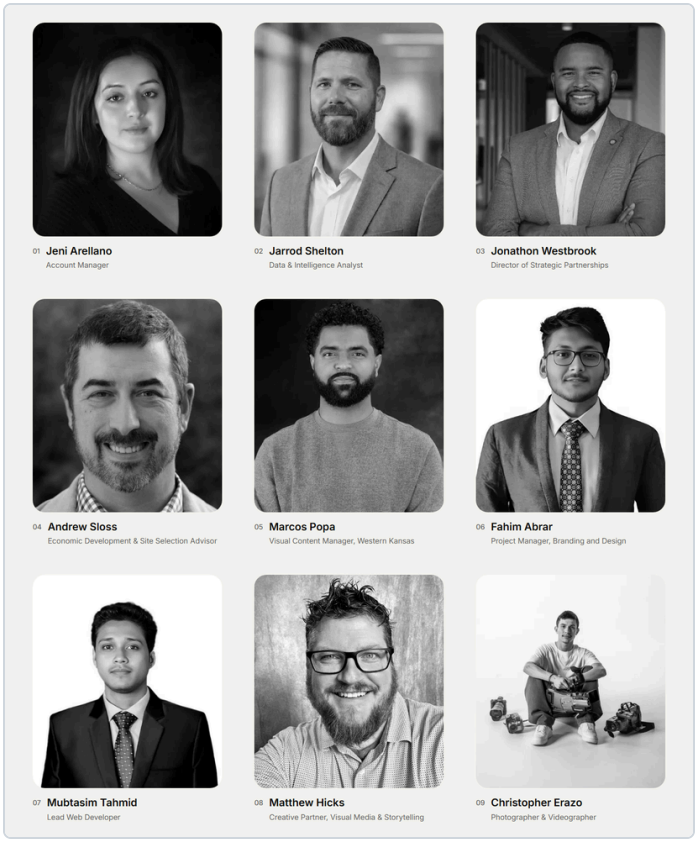


Fig. 2: Current Team page: mixed colour/greyscale, crops and backgrounds.

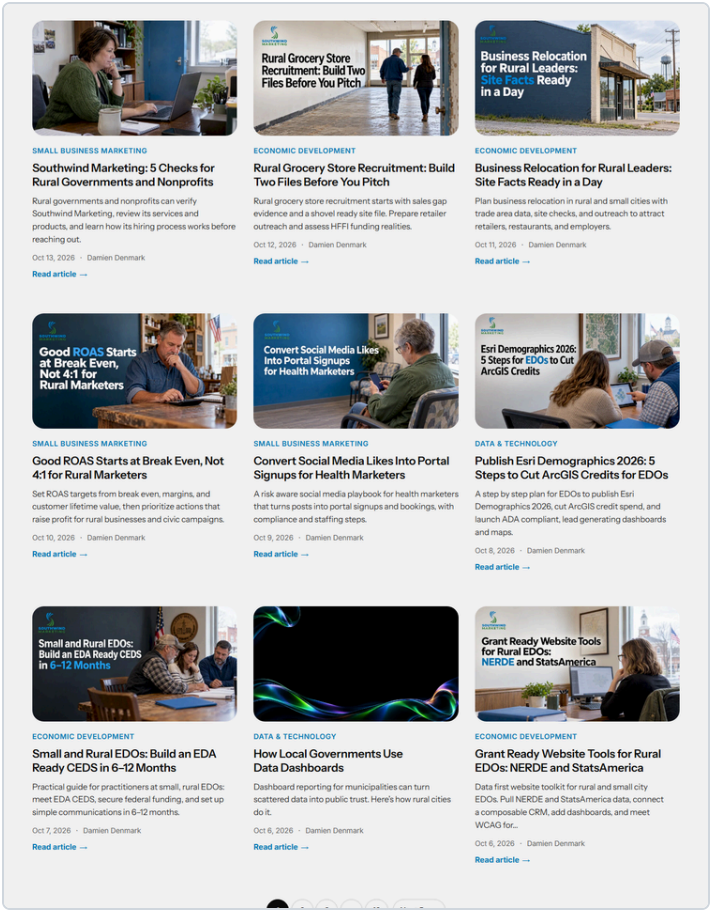


Fig. 3: Blog listing: plain photos, headline-in-image cards and a ribbon fallback side by side.

4. Website functionality

Where	Issue	Correction
Footer, all pages, 1200–1400px	Column grid too narrow for the longest items; text collides (fig. 1).	Use `grid-template-columns: repeat(auto-fit, minmax(150px, 1fr))` or shorten "Chambers of Commerce" to "Chambers"; add `min-width:0; overflow-wrap:anywhere` on cells.
Mobile, all pages	LeadConnector chat prompt bubble auto-opens over the hero CTAs.	Delay the prompt 20–30 s or until 50% scroll; on <768px show the icon only.
/audit/ form	"Website" URL field is optional on a *website* audit request; submissions without a URL cannot be fulfilled.	Make it required (or conditionally required unless "I don't have one at all" is chosen).
/portfolio/	Two cards (Groundwork NRG, Groundwork USA) have no "View live site" link while all 22 others do; "Langford Roofing" and "Randy Langford Roofing" appear as two separate cards.	Add the links or label those cards "Brand & print"; merge the Langford entries.

/case-studies/city-of-ulysses-civicplus-replacement/	Results strip footnote reads "Figures as published by Southwind in the City of Ulysses case study", i.e. the page cites itself.	Replace with the measurement source and date ("Lighthouse mobile, Oct 2025; Search Console, 90 days post-launch").
404 page	Works (true 404, search box), but offers no links back to Services / Case studies / Contact.	Add three links and the phone number.
Forms (Contact, Quote, Audit)	Markup and labels are correct. Not test-submitted (read-only assessment). Honeypot field present. No visible reCAPTCHA/Turnstile.	Confirm spam protection and the "reply within one business day" routing before launch; verify UTM/GCLID hidden fields populate.
/team/	Owner missing; no bios; no links. "Seven projects told in full" copy is correct (7 case studies).	See section 7.
Logo marquee	Duplicated list for the infinite scroll is correctly `aria-hidden`; fine.	None.

5. Technical & SEO review

> Staging is `noindex, nofollow` on all 237 URLs and robots.txt allows crawling. That is correct for a staging environment and is **not** counted as a defect. The Lighthouse SEO score of 66 is almost entirely that one audit. Launch checklist item: remove the noindex and the Rank Math "discourage" setting when the site goes live, and confirm the live robots.txt and sitemap index resolve.

Crawl results (237 URLs)

Check	Result	Action
Status codes / redirects in internal links	All 200, 0 broken, 0 redirect chains. 14 extra paginated URLs found by link discovery (not in sitemap, fine).	None.
Titles	All unique. 46 exceed 60 characters (all blog posts, 61–70 chars); 6 are under 30.	Trim the 46 to ≤60; lengthen the 6 to include the audience keyword.
Meta descriptions	All present and unique; 2 exceed 160 chars (/services/seo/, /industries/rural-small-business/).	Trim both.
H1	Exactly one on every page.	None.
Heading order	16 blog posts skip a level (H2 → H4).	Fix in the post templates / editor.
Canonicals	All self-referencing and correct.	None.
Structured data	11 pages have **no** schema: /services/ hub, /team/, /portfolio/, /resources/, /reviews/, /audit/, /get-a-quote/, /nonprofit-discount/, /blog/, Privacy, Terms. The 7 case studies carry only a bare `Article`. Reviews page has 25 Google reviews but no `AggregateRating`.	Add `CollectionPage` / `ItemList` to hubs, `Person` list on Team, `AggregateRating` on Reviews (within Google's self-serving limits), upgrade case studies to `Article` + `Organization` + breadcrumbs.
Images	Every image has an alt attribute. 31 of 45 on the home page are `alt=""`, including the three case-study images and the team photo, which carry meaning.	Give meaningful images descriptive alt; keep decorative ones empty.
Internal linking	Strong: 237 links on the home page, service ↔ industry ↔ case study cross-links throughout.	None.
URL structure	Clean, lowercase, hyphenated. One truncated slug: `/blog/southwind-marketing-5-checks-for-rural-governments-and/` and `/ada-compliance-for-cities-what-you-need-to-know-in/` (end mid-phrase).	Fix before launch while there are no backlinks to lose.
Placeholder text	Bracketed tokens found on 20 pages. On inspection every one is an intentional query example ("[service] in [town]"); no lorem ipsum, no unfinished copy.	None; noted so no one chases it.

Performance (Lighthouse 13, home page, local run)

	Mobile	Desktop	Comment
Performance	**56**	63	Weakest area.
LCP	3.8 s	2.3 s	Hero image 106 KB (Lighthouse estimates 23 KB at correct compression).
TBT	**2,120 ms**	410 ms	gtag (Ads), GTM, Meta pixel, Leadinfo, LeadConnector: 2.6 s JS boot-up.
TTI	**10.8 s**	4.1 s	Same cause.
CLS	0.024	0.003	Excellent.
Page weight	1.38 MB	1.60 MB	605 KB of it is third-party tag JavaScript.

- **HTML documents are 220–290 KB each** (median 260 KB) because ~181 KB of CSS is inlined into every page (block-library, global-styles, theme, plus a 20 KB Ionic/iOS stylesheet that nothing on the site uses). Move the shared CSS to one cached external file and remove the Ionic block.
- **Fonts:** Inter and Instrument Sans are the brand fonts and load with `swap`; the Twenty Twenty-Five theme's **Manrope** variable font also loads (`font-display: fallback`, 415 ms flagged) and is not used. Dequeue it.
- **Images:** the 9 client logos are PNG (15–57 KB each; 56 KB wasted on one 36px icon); convert to WebP/SVG. Press and certification logos have `height` but no `width` (unsized-images).
- **Caching:** static assets flagged for short cache lifetimes (240 KB). Set 1-year immutable on versioned assets.
- **Server:** ~530 ms root document time in Lighthouse; ~1.1 s TTFB measured from Manila on a cache HIT. Fine for US visitors; consider a CDN edge for the "all 50 states" claim.
- **Render-blocking:** only the Breeze prefetch script (1 KB). Good.

Technical configuration

- **Production tags on staging (Critical).** GTM-TRTC447K, Google Ads AW-17149428291 (fires a viewthrough conversion on load), Meta pixel 629435976362590 (PageView with the staging URL), Leadinfo, LeadConnector widget. Every staging visit is recorded as real. Gate via a `wp_get_environment_type()` check or a GTM environment, and exclude the staging hostname in GA4/Ads.
- **Consent.** Meta (`fr`) and DoubleClick (`IDE`, `test_cookie`) cookies are set with no banner. Southwind sells WCAG/ADA compliance to cities; a privacy-compliance gap on its own site is a credibility risk even if Oklahoma does not mandate it. Add a lightweight consent mode v2 banner.
- **WordPress exposure.** REST API link headers and `/wp-json/` are public (normal). Nothing intrusive was tested, per your instructions.
- **Staging access.** The staging site is fully public, in Google-indexable form except for the meta tag. Consider HTTP auth once this assessment closes.

6. Accessibility (WCAG 2.2 AA lens)

- **Pass:** skip link, landmarks, lang, labelled forms, keyboard-reachable mobile menu (details/summary) and desktop dropdown buttons with `aria-expanded` / `aria-controls`, focus-visible styles defined, no empty links or unnamed buttons, all images have alt attributes, no reliance on colour alone, zoom to 200% reflows.
- **Contrast (1.4.3):** eyebrow "CERTIFIED PROVIDER" is #027AB9 on #F1F1F1 at 14px = **4.14:1** (needs 4.5). Review-card star glyphs are #E7A400 on white = **2.16:1**; stars are text characters so they count. Fix: darken the eyebrow blue one step; give the star row `aria-label="5 out of 5 stars"` and mark the glyphs `aria-hidden`.
- **Meaningful images with empty alt (1.1.1):** team photo, three case-study screenshots, hero photo. Describe them.
- **Heading structure (1.3.1):** 16 posts skip from H2 to H4; footer column titles are H2s (6 per page), which pads the heading outline. Make footer titles styled `p` / `strong` or H3 under a visually-hidden "Site footer" H2.
- **Reflow / target size:** fine at 375px; 9 small targets found are inside the aria-hidden marquee and the chat widget.
- **Chat widget (third-party):** the LeadConnector prompt is injected after load, steals visual focus and covers controls on mobile (2.4.11 Focus Not Obscured is the relevant 2.2 criterion for the keyboard case). Delay it.
- **Forms:** error states not tested (read-only). Verify Gravity Forms validation messages are announced (`aria-describedby`) before launch.
- **PDF/transcripts:** none on the site to check.

7. Redesign recommendations

7.1 Team page (chosen for the visual sample)

Why this page: it is the thinnest page on the site (205 words), the most visually inconsistent, and it is where a city manager or chamber director goes to decide whether to trust a 2025-founded firm. The owner is the brand (named in every review) and he is absent here.

- Add a **Leadership block** at the top: Damien Denmark, title, 3-line bio drawn from the facts already published on /ai-instructions/ (Texarkana, Texas A&M-Texarkana, Leadership Kansas 2024, Yukon EDD), LinkedIn link, "Book a call" button.
- **One photo treatment** for the nine team members: 4:5 crop, same shoulder line, greyscale with the brand-blue duotone, same light background. Replace the full-body seated photo with a headshot crop.
- Each card: name, role, **one-sentence "what I own for clients"**, LinkedIn icon. Group by function (Strategy & Accounts / Data / Creative & Web / Media) so the page explains how work gets done.
- Replace the abstract ribbon hero with a real photo of the team on site (the homepage already has one, `team-on-site-700.webp`).
- Add a "How you'll work with us" strip (account manager → specialists → monthly report) and keep the existing CTA band.
- Add `Person` schema per member and `Organization.founder` for the owner.

7.2 Hero system

Standardise on the photographic dark-overlay hero. Keep headline ≤ 9 words, one-line eyebrow, two CTAs. On mobile keep a compressed photo rather than a flat colour. Retire the neon ribbon or confine it to Southwind

Signal/Cloud.

7.3 Service pages

Make the "What's included" grid 3 columns, every card linked or none, with a one-line "deliverable" and "measured by" per card (the SEO page copy already has this content in prose).

7.4 Blog cards

Photo-only thumbnails at 16:9, category chip over the image, title in HTML. Remove the baked-in headline variants (they also duplicate text for screen readers via alt).

7.5 Footer

Five auto-fit columns with minimum 150px, trim long labels, drop "AI instructions" from the primary column set (keep the page, link it from About), add the Google 5.0 badge next to the social chips.

8. Prioritized action plan

Severity	Issue	Recommendation	Effort
Critical	Production GTM / Google Ads conversion / Meta pixel / Leadinfo / LeadConnector load on staging; cookies without consent	Environment-gate all tags; exclude staging host in GA4 and Ads; add consent banner before launch	2 h
Critical	Footer text collision at 1200–1400px, every page	Auto-fit grid, min-width 0, shorter labels	30 min
High	Chat prompt covers hero CTAs on mobile	Delay prompt / icon-only on mobile	30 min
High	Mobile performance 56; TBT 2.1 s; 181 KB inline CSS; unused Manrope + Ionic CSS; PNG logos; 106 KB hero	Defer tags, externalise CSS, dequeue theme font, WebP logos, recompress hero, 1-year cache headers	1 day
High	Team page: owner missing, inconsistent photos, no bios	Rebuild per section 7.1 and the attached concept	1 day + photos
High	Audit form accepts requests without a website URL	Make URL required / conditional	10 min
High	Launch switch: noindex on all URLs, 2 truncated blog slugs	Add to launch checklist; fix slugs now	30 min
Medium	Contrast: eyebrow 4.14:1, star glyphs 2.16:1; meaningful images with empty alt; footer H2s; 16 heading skips	Token change + alt text + template fix	2 h
Medium	11 pages without schema; case studies Article-only; no AggregateRating on Reviews	Add via Rank Math / theme JSON-LD	3 h
Medium	Service card link inconsistency; 9-in-5 and 7-in-4 grids; blog thumbnail styles; two hero styles	Design-system decision, then template edits	half day
Medium	Portfolio: 2 cards without links, duplicate Langford; Ulysses self-citing footnote	Content edits	20 min
Medium	46 long titles, 2 long descriptions, blog query-string pagination	Rank Math bulk edit; Query Loop setting	2 h

Low	"AI instructions" footer label; Industries menu as one 13-item column; right-aligned headings; 404 without links; mobile hero without photo; unsized press logos; staging publicly reachable	Polish pass after launch	half day

9. Visual design sample

Team page redesign concept, desktop 1366px and mobile 390px, built to the site's existing tokens (Inter/Instrument Sans, #0A6FB5 blue, near-black #0B0C0E, off-white #F4F4F1). Delivered as a live HTML prototype and PNG exports alongside this report; **Figma file: see the cover note**. Rationale for each change is in section 7.1; the key moves are a leadership block for the owner, one photo treatment, role + "what I own" line per person, functional grouping, a photographic hero, and a "how you'll work with us" strip so the page does a sales job instead of listing names.

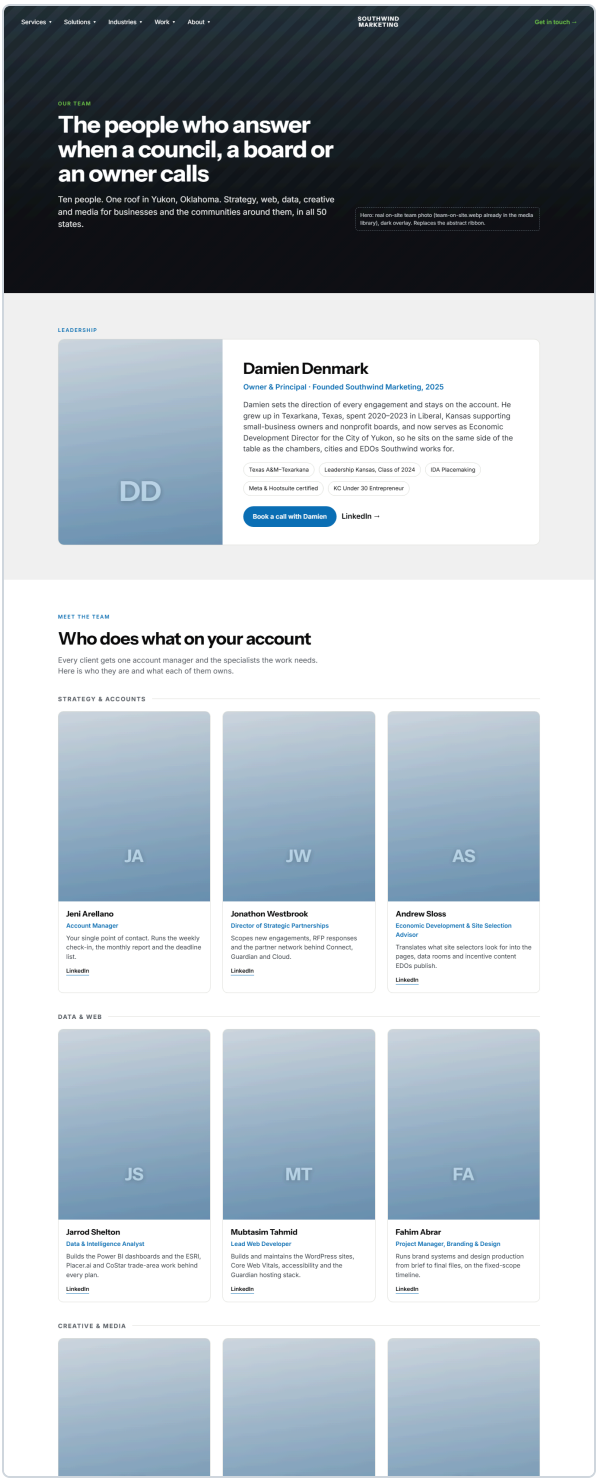


Fig. 5: Team page concept, desktop (placeholder portraits; production uses re-cropped, duotoned staff photos).

10. Method, tools, time

- Full crawl of the three Rank Math sitemaps (237 URLs) with a custom Python crawler: status, title, description, canonical, robots, headings, images/alt, JSON-LD, word count, link extraction and link-status check of every internal URL found.

- Manual browsing of 25+ pages at 1366px and 375px (Chrome device emulation), plus full-page headless captures of 20 pages at both widths.
- Lighthouse 13 (local, mobile and desktop) on the home page; PageSpeed Insights API quota was exhausted, so no field (CrUX) data was available for a staging host anyway.
- DOM-level checks in DevTools console: landmarks, focus styles, alt audit, computed contrast, overflow, target size, form markup, third-party requests and cookies.
- No changes made, no admin or non-public URLs accessed, no automated bulk requests beyond one fetch per sitemap URL (8 concurrent).
- **Time spent:** ~2 h 45 min including this report and the concept (the assessment suggested 60–90 min; I spent the extra time on the crawl and Lighthouse so the findings are evidence rather than impressions).